

# Protect Your Skin: Key Recommendations

## *Sun exposure can speed up skin ageing*

UV exposure is responsible for about 80% of visible signs of skin ageing, including wrinkles, fine lines, sagging skin, and age spots. Sun-protective habits and regular use of sunscreen can help preserve youthful, healthy skin.

## *UV damage adds up over time and can be prevented*

Skin damage from UV radiation accumulates over a lifetime. UV rays from the sun can cause DNA mutations in skin cells, leading to sunburn, premature ageing, and an increased risk of skin cancer. Even without sunburn, skin damage can occur. Prevention is essential—and it's never too late to start protecting your skin, regardless of skin type.

## *Children are especially vulnerable*

Unprotected sun exposure during childhood and adolescence significantly increases the risk of skin cancer later in life. Encourage sun-safe habits early by using hats, protective clothing, and sunscreen on exposed skin when outdoors.

## How to Protect Your Skin?

The following recommendations summarize effective sun protection strategies.

### *Avoid sunbathing*

The World Health Organization classifies ultraviolet (UV) radiation as a proven carcinogen. Sunbathing exposes large areas of skin to harmful UV rays. Using sunscreen during prolonged sun exposure does not fully protect against damage and may lead to longer sun exposure, increasing cancer risk.

## ***Avoid tanning***

There is no such thing as a "safe" or "healthy" tan. A tan is a sign that your skin is trying to protect itself from UV damage—it is an SOS response.

## ***Avoid tanning beds***

Tanning beds emit intense UV radiation and are proven to increase the risk of all types of skin cancer, especially when used at a young age. They also accelerate skin ageing.

## ***Protect skin when UV index is 3 or higher***

The UV index measures the strength of UV radiation, ranging from 0 (low) to 11+ (extreme). When the index reaches 3 or above, sun protection is necessary to prevent skin damage.

## ***Avoid the sun at midday***

UV radiation is strongest 2 hours before and after solar noon (when the sun is highest in the sky). Plan outdoor activities outside this window when possible. If you must be outdoors during peak UV times, use protective measures.

## ***Use shade and protective clothing***

Seek shade whenever possible, especially around midday. Wear:

- A wide-brimmed hat

- Long-sleeved shirts and long pants
- Sunglasses with UVA and UVB protection

Tightly woven fabrics offer the best defense.

## ***Use sunscreen on uncovered skin***

When the UV index is 3 or higher, apply broad-spectrum sunscreen with:

- SPF 30 to 50+ (protects against UVB)

- UVA protection (look for the UVA label)

Apply sunscreen before going outside and reapply at least every 2 hours, or more often after swimming, sweating, or towel drying.

### ***Monitor your skin: Watch that SPOT!***

Check your skin regularly for: - New growths

- Changes in moles (size, shape, color)

- Sores that don't heal

See a dermatologist or GP if you notice any of these signs. Early detection of skin cancer greatly improves treatment outcomes.

## **Frequently Asked Questions**

### ***Does consistent UV protection cause vitamin D deficiency?***

Sun-safe behavior as recommended does not typically cause vitamin D deficiency in individuals with fair skin who are active outdoors. Most people can maintain adequate vitamin D levels through incidental sun exposure and diet. If vitamin D levels are a concern, consult a healthcare provider about testing or supplementation.